

Word family: **try / tries / tried / trying / retry / trial**

Base word: try

Verb forms: try, tries, tried, trying

Noun: try

Useful related forms/extensions: trying, retry, trial

Useful fixed expressions: try to + verb, try + -ing, give something a try, try your best, nice try, tried and tested / tried and true

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “I still use them now, especially when I am travelling or **trying to focus**.”

A full family sweep shows that **try** has several genuinely useful senses. The single most important grammar distinction is:

> **try to do** ≠ **try doing**

That distinction matters directly in your sentence.

Meaning in this passage

Here:

> **trying to focus**

means:

making an effort to concentrate your attention, even though concentration may be difficult.

繁體中文: **正在努力把注意力集中起來／嘗試集中精神**

Natural translation:

> “I still use them now, especially when I am travelling or trying to focus.”

「我現在仍然會使用它們，尤其是在旅行或**想努力集中精神**的時候。」

So:

try to + verb = 努力嘗試做某事，重點在於「努力達成」

1. **try to + verb (行動／目標) — 努力嘗試做……; 設法……**

This is your original meaning.

Meaning: To make an effort to do or achieve something, especially when it may be difficult.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I use the headphones when I am **trying to focus**.”

「我**努力想集中精神**時會使用這副耳機。」

Practice 2

> “I’m **trying to finish** the report before lunch.”

「我正在**努力想在午餐前完成**報告。」

Practice 3

> “She **tried to open** the door, but it was locked.”

「她**嘗試把門打開**, 但門鎖上了。」

try to do = 作出努力, 希望成功完成某個行動或達到某個目標

Notice that **try to do** does **not** tell us whether the attempt succeeded.

> “She **tried to open** the door.”

She may have failed.

2. **try + -ing (方法／做法) — 試試看做……; 用……這個方法看看**

This is extremely important.

Meaning: To do something as an experiment to see whether it works, helps, or produces a desired result.

Practice 4

> “If you can’t focus, **try listening** to some quiet music.”

「如果你無法集中精神，可以**試試聽**一些輕柔音樂，看看有沒有幫助。」

Practice 5

> “**Try restarting** the computer.”

「**試試重新啟動電腦**，看看能不能解決問題。」

try doing = 把某個做法當作一種方法試驗，看看效果如何

Critical distinction: **try to do** vs **try doing**

try to do

= make an effort to accomplish it

> “I **tried to sleep**.”

「我**努力想睡著**。」

Maybe I couldn’t sleep.

try doing

= test it as a possible solution

> “**Try sleeping** with the window open.”

「**試試開著窗睡覺**，看看有沒有幫助。」

So in your sentence:

> **trying to focus**

means:

努力想集中精神

Not:

> **trying focusing** ❌

because focusing itself is the **goal**, not an experimental solution.

3. **try + noun**(食物／產品／活動) — 試試; 體驗一下

Meaning: To experience, taste, use, or do something to find out what it is like.

Practice 6

> “You should **try this dessert**.”

「你應該**試試這道甜點**。」

Practice 7

> “I’d like to **try the new headphones** before buying them.”

「我想在購買之前先**試用一下這副新耳機**。」

try something = 親自使用、品嚐或體驗某件事物, 看看它是怎樣的

This differs from **try to do**.

> **try the headphones** = 試用耳機

> **try to use the headphones** = 努力嘗試使用耳機

4. **try + method/approach**(方法／方案) — 試用; 採用看看

Practice 8

> “We **tried several different methods**.”

「我們**試過幾種不同的方法**。」

Practice 9

> “Let’s **try a different approach**.”

「我們**試試另一種方法**吧。」

****try a method/approach = 實際採用某種方法, 看看是否有效****

This overlaps with ****try doing****, but the grammar differs.

5. ****try = test whether something works/suits (測試／試用) — 試; 試驗****

Practice 10

> **“**Try the button** and see if it works.”**

「****試按一下這個按鈕****, 看看是否有效。」

Practice 11

> **“She **tried the key**, but it didn’t fit.”**

「她****試了那條鑰匙****, 但並不合適。」

****try = 實際測試某件物品或方法, 看看它能否正常運作／是否合適****

This grows naturally from the “experiment” sense.

6. ****try = attempt to contact/reach someone or somewhere — 試著聯絡／找……****

A common conversational use.

Practice 12

> **“I called his office, but no one answered, so I **tried his mobile**.”**

「我打去他的辦公室沒有人接, 所以我又****試著打他的手機****。」

Practice 13

> **“If this number doesn’t work, **try reception**.”**

「如果這個號碼打不通, 可以****試著聯絡接待處****。」

****try + person/place/contact method = 嘗試透過某人、地方或方式取得聯絡或得到協助****

7. **try** + case/person (法律) — 審理; 審判

This is a genuinely different and important formal meaning.

Meaning: For a court to formally examine a legal case and decide whether someone is guilty or legally responsible.

Practice 14

> “The case will be **tried** next year.”

「這宗案件將於明年**審理**。」

Practice 15

> “He was **tried** for fraud.”

「他因詐騙罪而**受審**。」

try — legal = 法院正式審理案件或審判被告，以決定法律責任／是否有罪

This is a formal legal use.

8. **a try** = an attempt (名詞) — 嘗試; 一試

Here, **try** is a noun.

Practice 16

> “I don’t know whether it will work, but it’s worth a **try**.”

「我不知道是否有效，但**值得一試**。」

Practice 17

> “Give it another **try**.”

「再**試一次**吧。」

a try = 為了成功做某件事而作出的一次嘗試

9. **give + something + a try — 試一試; 試用／體驗看看**

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 18

> “Why don’t you **give noise-cancelling headphones a try**?”

「你為甚麼不**試試降噪耳機**？」

Practice 19

> “I wasn’t sure about the app, but I decided to **give it a try**.”

「我原本不確定那個應用程式好不好，但最後決定**試一試**。」

give something a try = 親自試用／體驗某事物，看看效果或感受如何

10. **try your best / hardest — 盡力; 盡最大努力**

Practice 20

> “Just **try your best**.”

「只要**盡力而為**就可以了。」

Practice 21

> “She **tried her hardest** to finish on time.”

「她**竭盡全力**希望準時完成。」

try your best/hardest = 投入自己能做到的最大努力

11. **nice try / good try — 嘗試得不錯; 想得美／別想騙我**

This expression has two common tones.

A. Genuine encouragement

> “You didn’t win, but **good try**.”

「你雖然沒有贏，但**已經嘗試得很好了**。」

B. Humorous/sarcastic rejection

> “Can I convince you to do my work for me?”

> “**Nice try.**”

「我可以說服你幫我做工作嗎？」

「**想得美／這招對我沒用。**」

nice try = 可真誠稱讚某次努力；亦可諷刺地表示「你想騙／說服我，但沒有成功」

Context and tone completely change the Chinese.

12. **trying = difficult, annoying, or testing one’s patience — 令人難受／考驗耐性的**

This is a genuinely distinct adjective derived from **try**.

Practice 22

> “It has been a very **trying** week.”

「這一星期過得非常**艱難、令人心身疲累**。」

Practice 23

> “The constant delays were extremely **trying**.”

「不斷延誤真的非常**令人煩躁、很考驗耐性**。」

trying — adjective = 因困難、煩人或壓力大而非常考驗人的耐性或承受能力

Important:

> **trying to focus**

Here **trying** is a verb form = 正在嘗試

but:

> **a trying experience**

Here **trying** is an adjective = 令人難受／考驗耐性的

Same spelling, different grammatical role.

13. **tried and tested / tried and true** — 經過驗證而可靠的

A useful family expression.

tried and tested

especially common in British English

tried and true

especially common in American English

Practice 24

> “It is a **tried and tested** method.”

「這是一種**經過實際驗證、證明可靠的方法**。」

Practice 25

> “She returned to her **tried-and-true** strategy.”

「她重新採用了自己那套**經過長期驗證、可靠有效的策略**。」

tried and tested / tried and true = 經過實際使用和驗證，已證明有效可靠的

Here **tried** means essentially **tested**.

14. **retry** = try again (科技／一般) — 重試；再次嘗試

A useful modern family extension, especially in technology.

Practice 26

> “If the download fails, click **Retry**.”

「如果下載失敗，請按**重試**。」

Practice 27

> “The system automatically **retried** the connection.”

「系統自動**再次嘗試連線**。」

retry = 第一次嘗試失敗或未完成後再次嘗試

Very common in:

- * apps
- * software
- * networks
- * payments
- * downloads

15. **try** = score in rugby (欖球) — 達陣

This is a genuinely distinct sports noun meaning.

In rugby, a **try** is a way of scoring points by grounding the ball in the opponent's in-goal area.

Practice 28

> “He scored two **tries** in the match.”

「他在比賽中兩次**達陣得分**。」

Practice 29

> “The team scored a late **try**.”

「球隊在比賽後段取得一次**達陣**。」

try — rugby = 欖球比賽中把球合法帶入／壓在對方得分區而取得的得分方式

This has nothing to do with 「嘗試」 in modern usage, so it deserves a separate sense.

Family-extension note: **trial**

Trial is a closely related lexical family member and useful enough to flag, though it should not be treated as just another grammatical form of **try**.

Its major modern meanings include:

* **a trial / clinical trial** = 試驗; 臨床試驗

* **a trial period** = 試用期

* **a free trial** = 免費試用

* **a criminal trial** = 刑事審訊

* **trial and error** = 反覆嘗試、從錯誤中找出方法

Example:

> “The service offers a 30-day free **trial**.”

「這項服務提供 30 天**免費試用期**。」

And:

> “We solved the problem by **trial and error**.”

「我們透過**不斷嘗試並從錯誤中調整**，最後解決了問題。」

This is exactly the kind of closely related family member our family sweep should catch.

Important distinction: **try** vs **attempt**

They overlap strongly.

try

very common and natural in everyday English.

> “I’ll try to help.”

「我會試著幫忙。」

attempt

more formal and often emphasizes a deliberate effort at something difficult.

> “They attempted to rescue him.”

「他們嘗試進行救援。」

As nouns:

> “Give it a try.”

natural/conversational

> “They made an attempt.”

more formal

Important distinction: **try vs test**

try

= experience something or make an attempt

> “Try these headphones.”

「試試這副耳機。」

test

= examine systematically to determine performance, quality, or correctness

> “Engineers tested the headphones.”

「工程師對耳機進行測試。」

So:

trying a product = 試用

testing a product = 測試性能

Important distinction: **try** vs **practise/practice**

You already curated **practice**, and the distinction is important.

try

= make an attempt

> “I tried to play the song.”

「我嘗試彈這首歌。」

practise

= repeatedly do something to improve skill

> “I practised the song every day.”

「我每天練習這首歌。」

Trying once is not necessarily practising.

Important distinction: **try** vs **manage**

try to do

does not guarantee success.

> “I tried to open the door.”

「我嘗試開門。」

Maybe I failed.

manage to do

means the effort succeeded.

> “I managed to open the door.”

「我終於成功把門打開了。」

So:

****try = attempt****

****manage = successfully accomplish despite difficulty****

Excellent MCQ distinction.

Important distinction: **try vs succeed**

> “I tried.”

= 我嘗試了。

> “I succeeded.”

= 我成功了。

You can:

> ****try and fail****

or:

> ****try and succeed****

So ****try** itself never guarantees success******.

Important grammar: **try to focus vs try focusing**

Directly relevant to your sentence:

**I'm trying to focus.**

= ****我正在努力集中精神。****

Concentration is the ****goal****.

**Try focusing on your breathing.**

= **試試把注意力集中在呼吸上, 看看有沒有幫助。**

Focusing on breathing is being proposed as a **method/experiment**.

That small grammar difference changes the meaning significantly.

Family-extension sweep

After the full sweep, the useful modern family includes:

- * **try to + verb** = 努力嘗試做.....
- * **try + -ing** = 試試某個方法看看
- * **try + noun** = 試用／品嚐／體驗
- * **try a method** = 採用某方法試試
- * **try — legal** = 審理／審判
- * **a try** = 一次嘗試
- * **give it a try** = 試一試
- * **try your best/hardest** = 盡力
- * **nice try** = 嘗試得不錯; 亦可諷刺「想得美」
- * **trying — adjective** = 艱難而考驗耐性的
- * **tried and tested / tried and true** = 經驗證可靠的
- * **retry** = 重試
- * **try — rugby** = 達陣
- * **trial** = 試驗／試用／審訊等相關詞
- * **trial and error** = 反覆嘗試並從錯誤中修正

I would exclude rare derivatives such as **tryingly** or uncommon person nouns because they add little practical value.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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try to + verb	作出努力, 希望成功完成某個行動或達到某個目標
try + -ing	把某種做法當成一個可能的解決方法, 實際試試看效果
try + noun	親自使用、品嚐或體驗某物, 以了解效果或感受
try a method/approach	實際採用某種方法, 看看是否有效
try — contact	嘗試透過某個人、地方或聯絡方式取得聯繫
try — legal	法院正式審理案件或審判被告
a try	為了成功做某件事而作出的一次嘗試

give something a try	親自試用／體驗某事物, 看看效果如何	
try your best	投入自己能力範圍內最大的努力	
nice try — sincere	對某次雖未成功但值得肯定的努力表示鼓勵	
nice try — sarcastic	表示看穿對方的企圖;「想得美／這招沒用」	
trying — adjective	因困難、煩人或壓力大而非常考驗耐性或承受力的	
tried and tested/true	經過實際使用和驗證後已證明可靠有效的	
retry	第一次未成功後再次嘗試	
try — rugby	欖球中把球合法壓入對方得分區所得的達陣	
trial — family extension	與測試、試用或正式審訊有關的名詞	

For your original sentence

> “I still use them now, especially when I am travelling or **trying to focus**.”

The exact meaning is:

trying to focus = 正在努力把自己的注意力集中起來, 希望能成功專注

So:

> **especially when I am travelling or trying to focus**

= **「尤其是在旅行或努力想集中精神的時候。」**

And the key grammar point is:

> **try to focus** = 努力想集中精神

> **try focusing** = 試試採用「集中注意力」這個做法, 看看效果如何